



Alien Guitar Secrets

LESSON 3.2 USING INTERVALS TO NAVIGATE THE FRETBOARD

Introduction: The Power of Intervals for Fretboard Navigation

Intervals are more than just distances between notes—they are your roadmap to navigating the entire fretboard. Mastering intervals allows you to visualize the relationships between notes in any position, making it easier to transition between scales, chords, and different keys.

In this lesson, we'll explore how to use intervals as a tool to find notes more quickly, connect different areas of the neck, and improve your soloing and improvisation skills. By learning to recognize interval patterns, you'll be able to move freely across the fretboard, breaking out of position-based playing and achieving greater musical fluency.

Why Use Intervals for Fretboard Navigation?

Intervals are crucial for fretboard navigation because they provide a consistent framework for locating notes and understanding the spatial relationships between them. Once you recognize interval shapes and patterns, you can move between positions and keys without getting lost.

Benefits of Using Intervals to Navigate the Fretboard:

1. **Increased Fretboard Awareness:** You'll understand the connections between notes and how they relate to one another, making it easier to find your way around the neck.
 2. **Improved Transitions:** Quickly shift between different chord and scale shapes by visualizing their interval relationships.
 3. **Enhanced Soloing Skills:** Use intervals to create more dynamic, melodic solos by targeting specific intervals.
 4. **Better Understanding of Harmony:** Recognize how intervals fit within scales and chords, helping you construct and deconstruct harmonic structures.
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Step-by-Step Guide to Using Intervals for Navigation

Step 1: Understand the Interval Shapes on the Fretboard

Before you can use intervals for navigation, you need to know their shapes and how they appear on the fretboard. Each interval has a consistent shape (except for adjustments between the G and B strings).

Common Interval Shapes on the Guitar:

- **Minor 2nd (1 semitone):** One fret up on the same string.
- **Major 2nd (2 semitones):** Two frets up on the same string.
- **Minor 3rd (3 semitones):** Three frets up on the same string.
- **Major 3rd (4 semitones):** Four frets up on the same string, or one string up and one fret back.
- **Perfect 4th (5 semitones):** One string up on the same fret.
- **Perfect 5th (7 semitones):** One string up and two frets up.
- **Octave (12 semitones):** Two strings up and two frets up (or same fret, 12 frets up on the same string).

Visualizing these shapes will help you move across the neck more effectively.

Step 2: Practice Moving Across the Neck Using Intervals

1. **Choose a Starting Note:**
 - Pick a root note anywhere on the fretboard (e.g., G on the 3rd fret of the E string).
 2. **Locate an Interval from the Root:**
 - Choose an interval to locate from your root (e.g., a major 3rd). Move four frets up to find B on the same string or move to the 2nd fret of the A string to locate it.
 3. **Connect Multiple Intervals:**
 - Continue building on top of the chosen interval. If you've found B (major 3rd from G), now find a perfect 5th from B (move up two frets on the A string to the 4th fret).
 4. **Repeat with Different Intervals:**
 - Practice finding different intervals (e.g., minor 6th, perfect 4th) from the root to internalize their shapes.
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Step 3: Practice Interval Patterns on Different Strings

Understanding how intervals relate across different strings will give you a comprehensive view of the fretboard. Here's how:

1. Start on the Low E String:

- Choose a root note on the low E string (e.g., C on the 8th fret).
- Locate a perfect 5th on the A string (3rd fret), a major 3rd on the A string (10th fret), and an octave on the D string (10th fret).

2. Adjust for the G and B Strings:

- Because of the tuning difference between the G and B strings, interval shapes will shift. A major 3rd interval (normally one string up and one fret back) becomes one string up and on the same fret when crossing from G to B.

3. Connect Interval Shapes Across All Strings:

- Practice moving between intervals across all strings to see how they interact in different positions.

Using Intervals for Soloing and Improvisation

Intervals are a powerful tool for soloing because they allow you to target specific notes and create more melodic phrases. When you can see interval relationships, you'll be able to move freely across the fretboard, creating solos that are more intentional and expressive.

1. Targeting Intervals in a Solo:

- Start a solo by targeting specific intervals from the root note of the chord (e.g., targeting the major 3rd for a major chord).
- Use intervals to highlight the chord tones and create more harmonically connected solos.

2. Creating Motifs Using Intervals:

- Create a simple motif using a major 3rd interval and repeat it across the neck, transposing the motif to different keys using interval patterns.

3. Combining Intervals for Dynamic Solos:

- Use a mix of smaller intervals (e.g., minor 2nd) and larger intervals (e.g., perfect 5th) to add contrast and excitement to your solos.
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Exercises for Practicing Interval Navigation

Exercise 1: Interval Mapping Exercise

1. Choose a root note on the low E string.
2. Move up by different intervals (e.g., major 3rd, perfect 4th, etc.) until you reach the octave.
3. Repeat the exercise starting from the A string, D string, etc., to internalize the interval patterns.

Exercise 2: Interval Shifting

1. Choose a starting interval (e.g., minor 3rd) and play it on the low E string.
2. Shift the interval to the next position and play it on the A string, then the D string, and so on.

Exercise 3: Interval Soloing Practice

1. Use a backing track in any key.
2. Choose an interval to focus on (e.g., perfect 5th) and create phrases using that interval.
3. Practice moving between different intervals in your solo to create dynamic phrases.